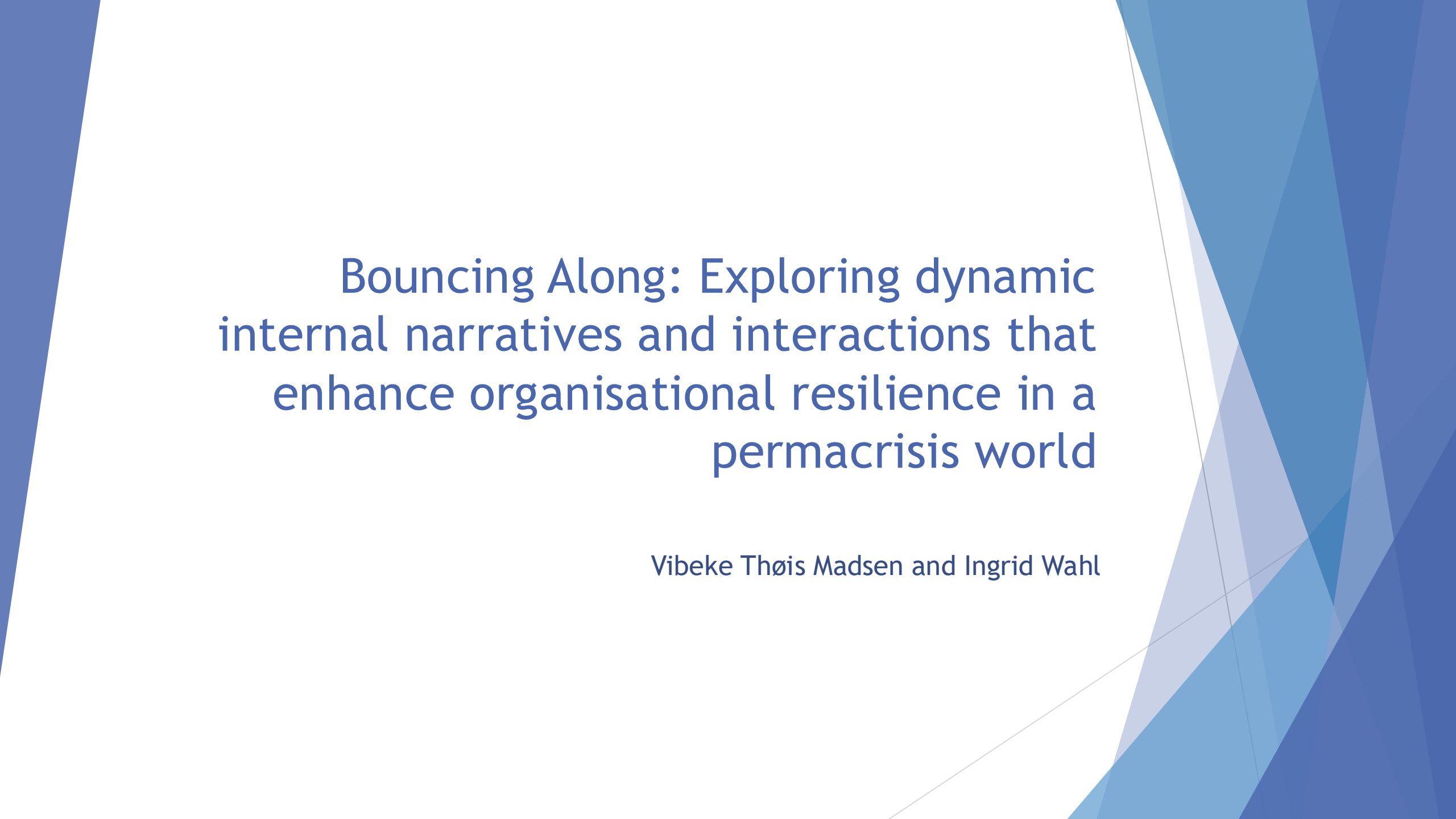




Bouncing Along: Exploring dynamic internal narratives and interactions that enhance organisational resilience in a permacrisis world

Vibeke Thøis Madsen and Ingrid Wahl

An ICRH-Europe Research Project



- ▶ The Internal Communication Research Hub (ICRH) Europe was formed in December 2024 and is part of the global hub that is housed within the University of Florida College of Journalism and Communications, led by Public Relations Professor Linjuan Rita Men.
- ▶ It is a voluntary group for academics and practitioners to share research and experiences that help to generate evidence-based, effective, and ethical internal communication practice.
- ▶ This research project was initiated by the group at the start of 2026.

Rationale for the research

- ▶ Continuing geo-political, societal, climate and economic uncertainties that seriously affect organisations today and will affect them in the near future.
- ▶ The situation is described by some as a permacrisis, with significant leadership challenges.
- ▶ Becker (2022, p.84) argues that “Resilience is the only way for organizations to grow and survive in today’s economy”.
- ▶ Cuenca-Fontbona et al. (2025, p.1) argue that “Current global challenges are reshaping the role of internal communication as a strategic function for organizational harmony”.
 - ▶ Although internal communication has not featured prominently in the organisational resilience literature to date, a leadership and culture perspective opens up a potentially important role for it.

Organisational Resilience: Bouncing back, forward or along?



David Hockney print: A Bounce For Bradford

Bouncing Back

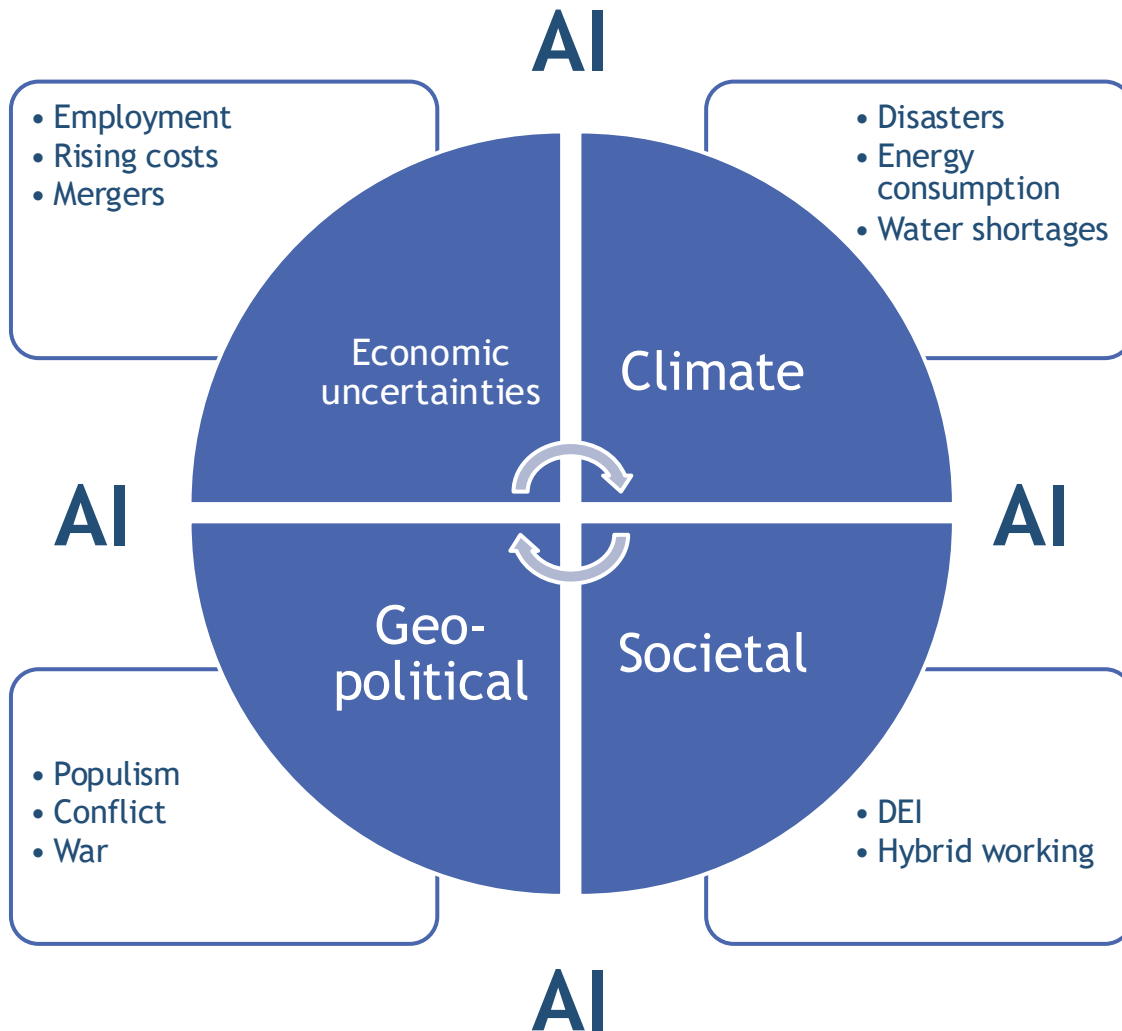
- Operational resilience is focused on survival and returning to the status quo.

Bouncing Forward

- "The maintenance of positive adjustment under challenging conditions such that the organisation emerges from those conditions strengthened and more resourceful" (Vogus and Sutcliffe, 2007, p.3418).

“There is a widespread consensus among corporate managers, policy makers, politicians, and planners that the future is full of disruption”
Halpern (2025, p.4582)

Constant and simultaneous cycles of change and crisis

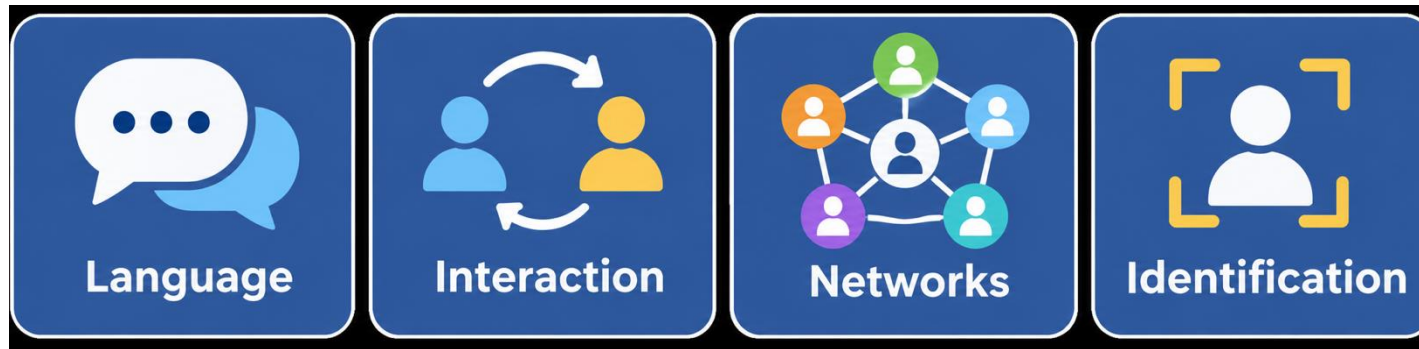


► Notions of “bouncing back” and “bouncing forward” often infer one-off episodes and this may not fully take account of a “polycrisis” situation, typified by simultaneous and interconnected crises that amplify each other’s effects (Brosig, 2025).

► To better reflect that resilience is no longer only related to one-off incidents, we introduce the concept of “bouncing along” in our research.

The communication theory of resilience (CTR)

Communication has most notably been explored in the resilience literature through the communication theory of resilience (CTR) which conceptualizes resilience as “a constitutive process through which people reintegrate and actively construct their new normal through...



(Buzzanell, 2019, p.68).

Internal communication and Organisational Resilience

- ▶ Buzzanell suggests that applying CTR to internal communication interventions can involve sensemaking and storytelling (Buzzanell and Houston, 2018).
 - ▶ However, CTR has not been explored in any depth in broader internal communication research.
- ▶ Zheng et al. (2025, p.2) state that “Existing literature has seldom examined how effective internal communication affects employees’ emotions and psychological resilience when encountering challenges”.

Narratives and sensemaking

- ▶ Language, storytelling and narratives recur across resilience and internal crisis communication studies and are highlighted in Heller et al.'s (2026) review of the history of internal communication in the UK.
- ▶ Flegg (2026) argues that sensegiving through narratives must be quickly followed by sensemaking if meaning is to be created.
- ▶ Meneghel et al. (2016) found that employees who maintain a high-quality relationship with their organisation are more likely to develop resilience.
- ▶ As Nowak (2020) points out, retrospective sensemaking must be negotiated between leaders and members and leadership must engage in narrative listening.
- ▶ In times of ongoing change in a permacrisis world, senior leader interactions with employees may be more important than ever to enable organisations to “bounce along” and become more resilient.

Research Questions

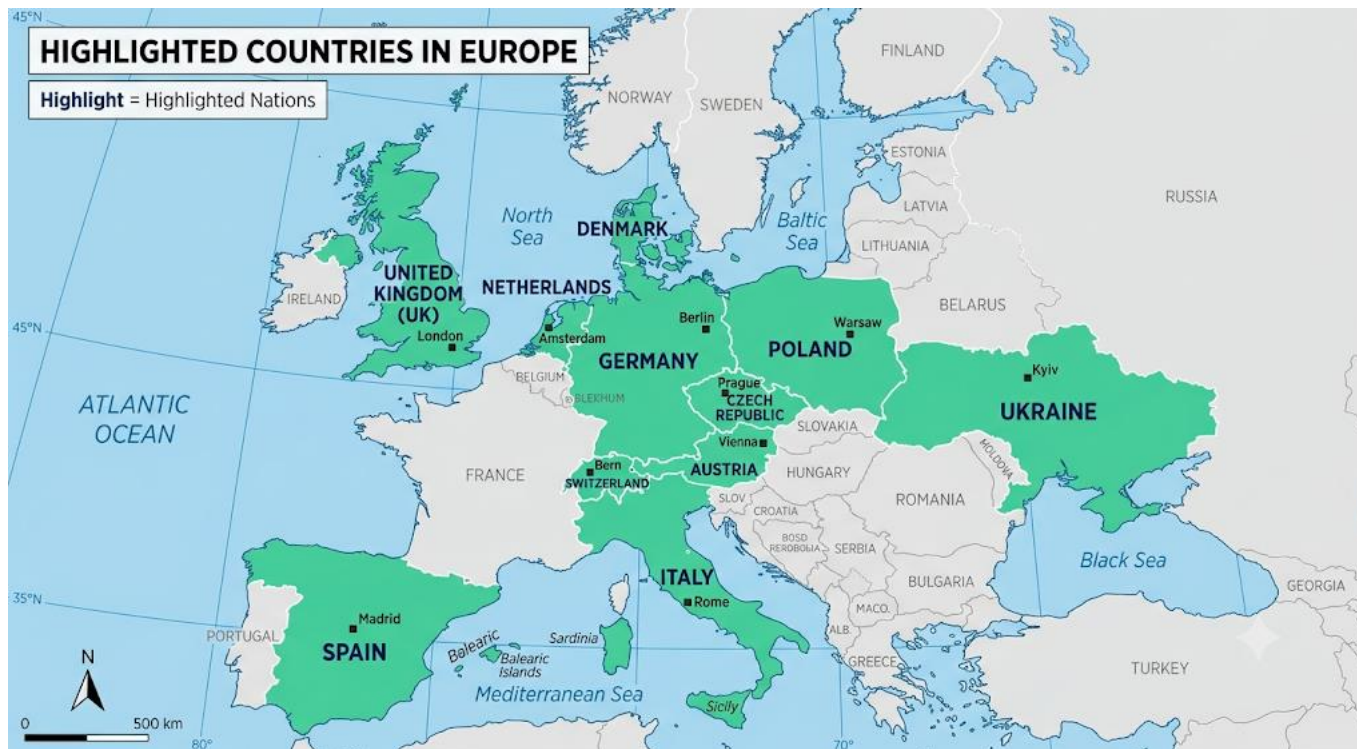
1. How is resilience understood by senior leaders?
2. How does internal communication help employees to become more resilient?
3. How does internal communication help organisations to become more resilient?
4. What role do internal narratives play in times of multiple change programmes?
5. What role do personal interactions between senior leaders and employees play in times of multiple change programmes?

Research Design: Three Waves

- ▶ **Wave 1: Qualitative.** Interviews and Focus Groups with internal communication practitioners. August to December 2026.
- ▶ **Wave 2: Quantitative:** Surveys with employees. February to April 2027.
- ▶ **Wave 3: Qualitative:** Interviews with senior leaders. January to March 2028.

Wave One

- ▶ 40-50 interviews with internal communication practitioners
- ▶ 10 focus groups with internal communication practitioners
 - ▶ Across Europe



References

- ▶ Becker, L. 2022. Organizational resilience and organizational change management. *Journal of Entrepreneurship and Business Resilience*, 5(1), pp.83-86.
- ▶ Brosig, M. 2025. How do crises spread? The polycrisis and crisis transmission. *Global Sustainability*, 8, p.e11.
- ▶ Buzzanell, P. M. 2019. Communication theory of resilience in everyday talk, interactions, and network structures. In S. R. Wilson and S. W. Smith (Eds.), *Reflections on Interpersonal Communication Research* (pp. 65-88). San Diego, CA: Cognella.
- ▶ Buzzanell, P. M. and Houston, J. B. 2018. Communication and resilience: Multilevel applications and insights-A Journal of Applied Communication Research forum. *Journal of Applied Communication Research*, 46(1), pp.1-4.
- ▶ Cuenca-Fontbona, J., Estanyol, E. and Echaburu-Mulet, B. 2026. Perspectives and Challenges of Internal Communication: Insights from Senior Management. *International Journal of Strategic Communication*, pp.1-25.
- ▶ Flegg, M. 2026. Change and Internal Crisis Communication. In Ruck, K. and Flegg, M. *Exploring Internal Communication: Towards Dialogue in the Workplace*, 5th Edition. London: Routledge.
- ▶ Meneghel, I., Martinez, I. M. and Salanova, M. 2016. Job-related antecedents of team resilience and improved team performance, *Personnel Review*, 45(3), pp.505-522.
- ▶ Nowak, R. O. 2021. Communicating for business resilience. *Journal of Business Continuity & Emergency Planning*, 14(4), pp.369-377.
- ▶ Vogus, T. J. and Sutcliffe, K. M. 2007. Organizational resilience: Towards a theory and research agenda. In 2007 IEEE International Conference on Systems, Man, and Cybernetics, SMC 2007., 4414160, Conference Proceedings - IEEE International Conference on Systems, Man and Cybernetics, pp. 3418-3422, 2007 IEEE International Conference on Systems, Man, and Cybernetics, SMC 2007, Montreal, QC, Canada, 10/7/07.
- ▶ Zheng, D., Xu, J., Tao, M. and Pratt, S., 2025. "Communication matters": Impacts of motivating language and internal communication on hotel employees' emotions, psychological resilience, and work engagement. *Tourism and Hospitality Research*, p.14673584251376643.